

17: ANOTHER PAIR OF EYES

第十七話

もう一つの目



AFTER HOURS.
THE ART ROOM.

INOUE HANA.
17.
SECOND-YEAR
ART STUDENT.

HANDS PERMANENTLY
STAINED BLACK
AT THE FINGERTIPS.

SHE HAS DRAWN THIS
BUILDING A HUNDRED
TIMES SINCE EPISODE 8.
IT KEEPS GROWING.

A SECOND STRUCTURE.
DIFFERENT ARCHITECTURE.
A FOREIGN SKYLINE
AT ITS EDGE.

SHE HAS NEVER BEEN
TOLD WHY SHE KEEPS
ADDING IT.

SHE DOES NOT KNOW...
SORA'S KEY HAS
RESONATED WITH THIS
EXACT BUILDING'S MIRROR
IN A DIFFERENT COUNTRY.

HER HAND
SIMPLY KNOWS.

EPISODE 8.
"THE FIRST KEY."



NODE.
CONNECTS.
MIRRORS.

SAME FORM.
DIFFERENT PLACE.
SAME TRUTH.

ART ROOM
AFTER COUNCIL

INOUE HANA, 17
CHARCOAL STAINED.
UNFILTERED.

SEES WHAT
OTHERS SKIP.

REIKA TENDO, 18
THE READER
OF THE PAST.
CARRIES WHAT
OTHERS FORGET.

BEFORE A SINGLE WORD
THE COST FINDS HER
FIRST.

INOUE.

WILL YOU
COME
SOMEWHERE
WITH ME
TONIGHT?

THERE IS
SOMETHING
I'VE BEEN
PUTTING OFF
SHOWING
YOU.

ME?

THE CORRIDORS
EMPTY AT DUSK.

SAME STEPS.
SAME SILENCE.

HER HAND KEEPS
DRIFTING TO
THE LATCH.

AND PULLING BACK.

OVER AND OVER.

INOUE NOTICES.

BUT DOESN'T
UNDERSTAND.

HER OWN HANDS
TWIST AND TWIST
AT THE APRON
STRINGS.

QUIET ANXIETY.

SHE'S CROSSED
THIS DOOR
A HUNDRED TIMES.

BUT NEVER
LIKE THIS.

BEYOND THIS DOOR,

THE PAST DOESN'T
STAY BURIED.

HER PERFECT
ARMOR...

BEGINS TO
FRACTURE.

AND TONIGHT—

INOUE HANA
WALKS BESIDE HER.

INTO THE OLD WING.

THE FIVE AT THE THRESHOLD

FIRST GATHERING. FIRST OPENING.

KAI MORI — 17
 SORA MINABE — 16
 ASTRID BRANDT — 17
 REIKA TENDO — 18
 INOUE HANA — 17



KAI MORI
OBSERVES.
ANALYZES.
EMOTIONS:
IRRELEVANT.



SORA MINABE
HOLDS THE KEY.
BEARS THE
WEIGHT.



ASTRID BRANDT
SEES THROUGH
EVERYTHING.
FEARS NOTHING.



REIKA TENDO
MAINTAINS ORDER.
EVERY MOVEMENT
A COMMAND.



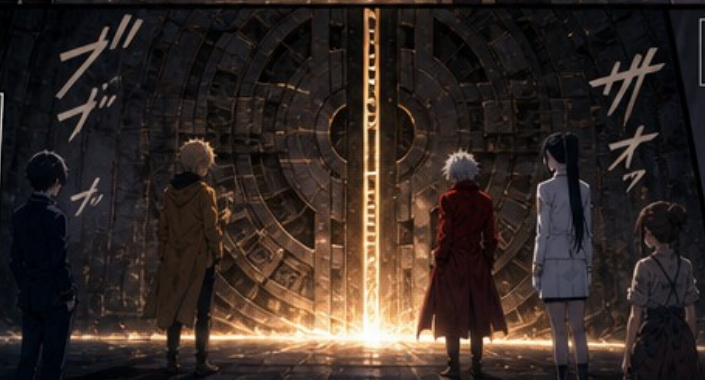
INOUE HANA
RECOGNIZES.
WHAT SHE DREW
WITHOUT KNOWING...
IS REAL.



THE KEY
KNOWS ITS PLACE.



THE MECHANISM
YIELDS.
AS ALWAYS.



THE FIELD—WARMTH...
THE TEXTURE...

EXACTLY AS
HER DRAWINGS
DEPICTED.

FIVE READERS. ONE THRESHOLD.
THE NETWORK STIRS.
TRUTH AWAITS.

THE NODE CHAMBER.

S1: SHARED PERCEPTION ORIGIN.

FIVE STEPS.
THAT'S ALL IT
TOOK TO BRING
US HERE.

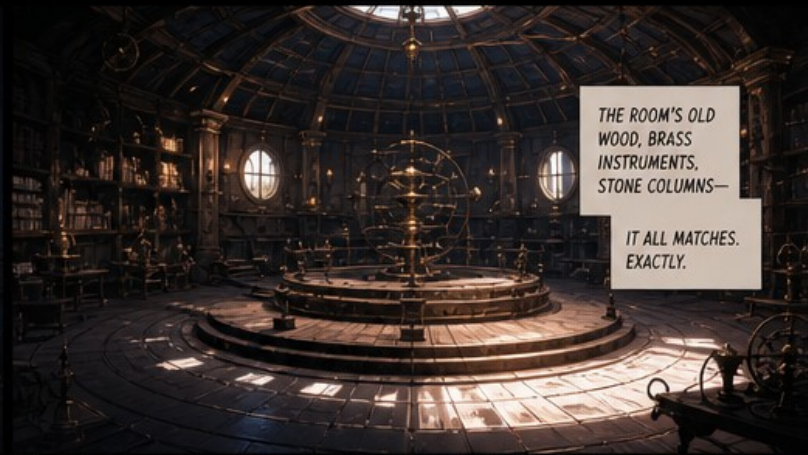
BUT FOR
ME—

IT WAS LIKE
WALKING INTO
A DRAWING I'D
BEEN MAKING
IN MY SLEEP.
FOR MONTHS.



THE ROOM'S OLD
WOOD, BRASS
INSTRUMENTS,
STONE COLUMNS—

IT ALL MATCHES.
EXACTLY.



THIS ISN'T
DATA.

THIS ISN'T
MEMORY.

THIS IS...
SOMETHING
ELSE.

CHARCOAL.
CHALK DUST.

THE RESIDUE
OF SOMETHING
THAT WAS.

DRAWING ITSELF
AROUND WHAT
ISN'T THERE
ANYMORE.



MY BREATH
CATCHES.

BECAUSE I
RECOGNIZE
IT.

EVERY LINE.
EVERY CURVE.
EVERY DETAIL—

I'VE BEEN
DRAWING THIS
PLACE WITHOUT
EVER KNOWING
I WAS.

I HAVEN'T
JUST FOUND
THE CHAMBER.

IT FOUND
ME FIRST.



INOUE HANA, 17.
CHARCOAL-STAINED APRON,
AMBER EYES.
MOVES SLOWLY TOWARD
THE ROOM'S CENTRE
WHERE THE DUST-PARTICLES
GATHERED THICKEST.

HER GIFT READING
THE AFTERMATH OF THE
S: SHARED PERCEPTION
WITH INCREASING CLARITY.

THE CHARCOAL DUST
THICKENING INTO A FAINT
OUTLINED SHAPE, THREE
FIGURES SUGGESTED IN
NEGATIVE SPACE—EXACTLY
WHERE KAI, REIKA, AND SORA
STOOD WHEN THE TRUTH
SET LIKE CONCRETE.

HER STAINED HAND
REACHING TOWARD
THE OUTLINE WITHOUT
TOUCHING IT, FEELING
THE RESIDUAL WARMTH
THE FIELD-GEOMETRY
LEFT BEHIND—

A SENSATION SHE
DESCRIBES LATER AS
"LIKE A ROOM AFTER
SOMEONE HAS JUST
LEFT IT, EXCEPT THE
SOMEONE LEFT MONTHS
AGO AND THE WARMTH
NEVER FADED."

HER FACE FILLING
WITH A COMPLEX
MIXTURE OF AWE
AND GRIEF—

AWE AT THE SCALE
OF WHAT HAPPENED
HERE, GRIEF AT A
FEELING SHE CANNOT
YET NAME.

SHE TURNS, FINDS
REIKA WATCHING
HER FROM THE
CHAMBER'S EDGE.

SOMEONE WAS
HERE BEFORE.
SOMEONE WHO
FELT LIKE ME.

REIKA TENDO.

STANDS RIGID AND IMMACULATE
IN HER LIGHT GREY BLAZER
WITH PROMINENT GOLD TRIM,
DARK TIE FASTENED WITH
PRECISION, PRISTINE DARK
PLEATED SKIRT, HER LONG
STRAIGHT BLACK HAIR BOUND
IN A DISCIPLINED HIGH PONYTAIL,
WHITE GLOVES COVERING HER
HANDS IN ABSOLUTE REFUSAL
TO TOUCH ANYTHING.

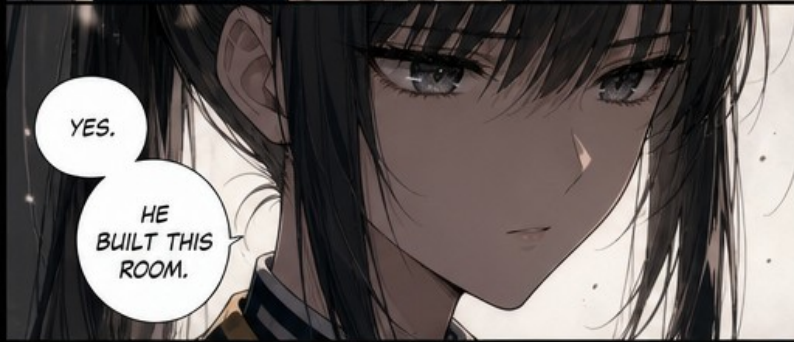
HER DARK EYES ARE DIRECT
AND UNFLINCHING YET MARKED
BY HIDDEN, PROFOUND
EXHAUSTION.

HER POSTURE IS PERFECTLY
SYMMETRICAL AND ASSERTIVE,
HER EXPRESSION SERIOUS AND
COMPOSED, MASKING OVERWHELMING
BURDEN.

SHE WATCHES INOUE'S READING
WITH THE CONTROLLED INTENSITY
OF ONE WHO KNOWS EXACTLY WHAT
THOSE DUST-OUTLINED ABSENCES
MEAN, HER PERFECTION ARMORING
HER AGAINST THE TERRIFYING HISTORY
FLOODING THROUGH THIS SPACE.

THE LINE "SOMEONE WHO FELT LIKE ME" LANDS WITH
FULL UNSPOKEN SIGNIFICANCE BETWEEN THEM AS
THE SCENE'S EMOTIONAL CORE.

THE CHAMBER ITSELF DENSE WITH SETTLING PARTICLES
CATCHING FRAGMENTARY LIGHT, THE SILENCE BETWEEN
THE TWO GIRLS ABSOLUTE AND SUFFOCATING.



YES.

HE
BUILT THIS
ROOM.



...YES.

HE...
HE WAS
HERE.

NOT A
STORY.
NOT A
RUMOR.



TRUE.

COMPLETE
IN ITSELF.

BOUNDED.



THANK
YOU.



HE
BUILT
THIS
ROOM.

...AND
SHE
WON'T
SAY
MORE.



PARTIAL
TRUTH.

HONESTY
AS
STRATEGY.

INTERESTING.



SHE
FINALLY
HEARD
HIM.

EVEN IF
IT'S ONLY
THIS.

The Node Chamber
Central Observation Lattice

Your gift reads truth through dust particles.

Let's treat it like any system.

I have a few technical questions.

INOUE HANA, 17
The Particulate Reader

< Reads residual truth from environmental dust through resonant frequency. >

What is the resolution threshold of your reading?

Minimum particle mass required?

How does humidity interfere with resonance?

Is the reading linear, or does it plateau beyond a saturation point?

Can you isolate an individual's truth from overlapping resonance fields?

And most importantly—

What is the decay rate of the signal once the source leaves the vicinity?

The Questions Land

The Conditions

Resolving Threshold: 0.3µg
Min. Particle Mass: 0.1µg
Humidity Interference: High
Resonance Curve: Non-linear
Saturation Point: 78.6%
Signal Isolation: Possible
(With Focus Lock)
Decay Rate: 3.2s

Accurate.
Useful.
Necessary.

And Also...

A beautiful mind.

Treating me like an instrument.

Observation
Log: Tendo Reika

Subject: Kai Mori
Behavioral Pattern:
Detachment (+)
Empathy (-)

First noted
fracture in
operational
harmony.

...Disappointing.

Brilliance
without
warmth.

Accuracy
without
consideration.

The most
precise kind of
failure.



The Node
Chamber.

Continuous
ASTRID
BRANDT.

Subjective
POV.

The chamber's
present social
configuration—
visible only
to me.

REIKA TENDO.

18.

Student Council
President.

Absolute authority.

Hidden exhaustion.

Subjective POV:
The amber-brown web
threading between
REIKA TENDO and
INOUE specifically.

Dense. Old.

The unmistakable color
of long-buried complicity.

INOUE.

Heir.

The thread
runs deeper
than he knows.

It reaches his
grandfather.

It reaches
her family.

I see it all.

Across global
systems.

The truth
neither of them
has spoken.

The complicity.
The bargain.
The silence
passed down.

It is all here.

I could
name it.

Right now.

Plainly.
Sharply.

The way
I name
everything.

I do not.

I look away.

Deliberately.

The first time
they will never
know I chose
silence.

The thread
remains.

At the edge
of vision.

A truth I carry.

A mercy I
will not name.

My first act of mercy.

Disguised as indifference.

The node does not shift.

But I do.

A little.

THE NODE CHAMBER.
CONTINUOUS.

SORA MINABE, 16.
THE READER OF
THE FUTURE.

INOUE HANA, 17.
THE READER OF
AFTERMATH.

CONSEQUENCE-
DREAD shows
where a surfaced
truth is heading.

AFTERMATH-
READING shows
what a surfaced
truth left behind.

SAME SPOT.
DIFFERENT
ANGLE.
DIFFERENT
TIME.

SAME SPOT.
DIFFERENT
ANGLE.
DIFFERENT
TIME.

YOU FEEL IT
GOING BACKWARD.

I FEEL IT
GOING FORWARD.

...

HE SEES
THE FUTURE
THAT TRUTH
BECOMES.

ORTHOGONAL COMPLEMENT.

TOGETHER, A COMPLETE ARC
NEITHER CAN PRODUCE ALONE.

THE NETWORK WAS NEVER
JUST THREE PEOPLE.

SHE SEES
THE AFTERMATH
THAT TRUTH
LEAVES.

TWO READERS.
INCOMPATIBLE FUTURES.
COMPLEMENTARY HALVES.

THE NODE CHAMBER. CONTINUOUS.

...THEN THE CONSEQUENCE ISN'T RANDOM.



IT HAS A SOURCE.

INOUE HANA, 17
AFTERMATH-READING:
CONSEQUENCE TRACE

DRAWN BY SORA'S MENTION OF CONSEQUENCE, INOUE'S AFTERMATH-READING DRIFTS OUTWARD...

THE CHARCOAL-DUST PARTICLES SHIFT DIRECTION, GATHERING NEAR A SPECIFIC SECTION OF WALL.



THE SAME AREA REIKA'S FAMILY BINDER REFERENCES AS ADJACENT TO THE OLD INDUSTRIAL-ERA RECORDS DESTROYED AFTER THE WAR.

THE DUST OUTLINES THE SHAPE OF DOCUMENTS THAT ONCE EXISTED HERE.

BURNED.
REMOVED.
DESTROYED.



THE SAME POSTWAR DESTRUCTION PATTERN CONNECTING TO THE CONTAMINATION CASE'S BURIED ORIGIN FROM EPISODE 16.

REIKA'S FAMILY BINDER
SECTION 7 - APPENDIX

Old Industrial
Records Storage
(Destroyed Postwar)

- Adjacent Wall
- See Map Ref.



Postwar Destruction
Records Purged
- 1945-1947



THERE WERE PAPERS HERE.

THEY'RE GONE.

BUT THE GONE-SHAPE IS THE SAME AS SOMETHING I FELT AT THAT FENCE THE OTHER DAY.



I DON'T KNOW WHAT IT MEANS. JUST... SHARING WHAT I SEE.

TURN



...THE FENCE.

!

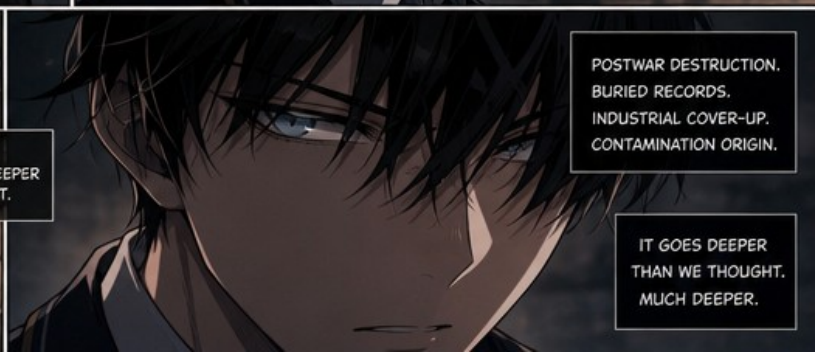
THE FENCE.
THE DEVELOPMENT SITE.
REIKA'S RECLASSIFICATION-DAY VISION.

THE THREADS JUST FOUND A DEEPER HISTORICAL ROOT.



POSTWAR DESTRUCTION.
BURIED RECORDS.
INDUSTRIAL COVER-UP.
CONTAMINATION ORIGIN.

IT GOES DEEPER THAN WE THOUGHT. MUCH DEEPER.



THE NODE CHAMBER
DEEP LEVEL / WARD 7

THE PATTERN
ISN'T RANDOM.
IT'S LAYERED.

SOMETHING'S
BEHIND THIS
WALL.

FIVE PEOPLE.
BUILT FOR THREE.
THE ROOM
IS HOLDING.

KAI MORI

HYPER-FOCUSED.
SEES PATTERNS
NO ONE ELSE
CAN.

REIKA TENDO

STEPPING BACK.
LETTING INOUE
WORK.
A RARE ACT OF
DEFERENCE.

SORA MINABE

THE INVISIBLE
BOY, FINALLY
SEEN.
CARRYING MORE
THAN HE SAYS.

ASTRID BRANDT

CROSS-REFERENCING.
CONNECTING DOTS.
ACROSS DECADES.
IRONY AS ARMOR.

INOUE HANA

FOUND IT.
UNDERSTANDS IT.
ALONE.
AS ALWAYS.

THIS WALL...

IT'S NOT
SUPPORTING
WEIGHT.

IT'S HIDING
SOMETHING.

THERE'S
A NODE
BEHIND IT.

I CAN
FEEL IT.

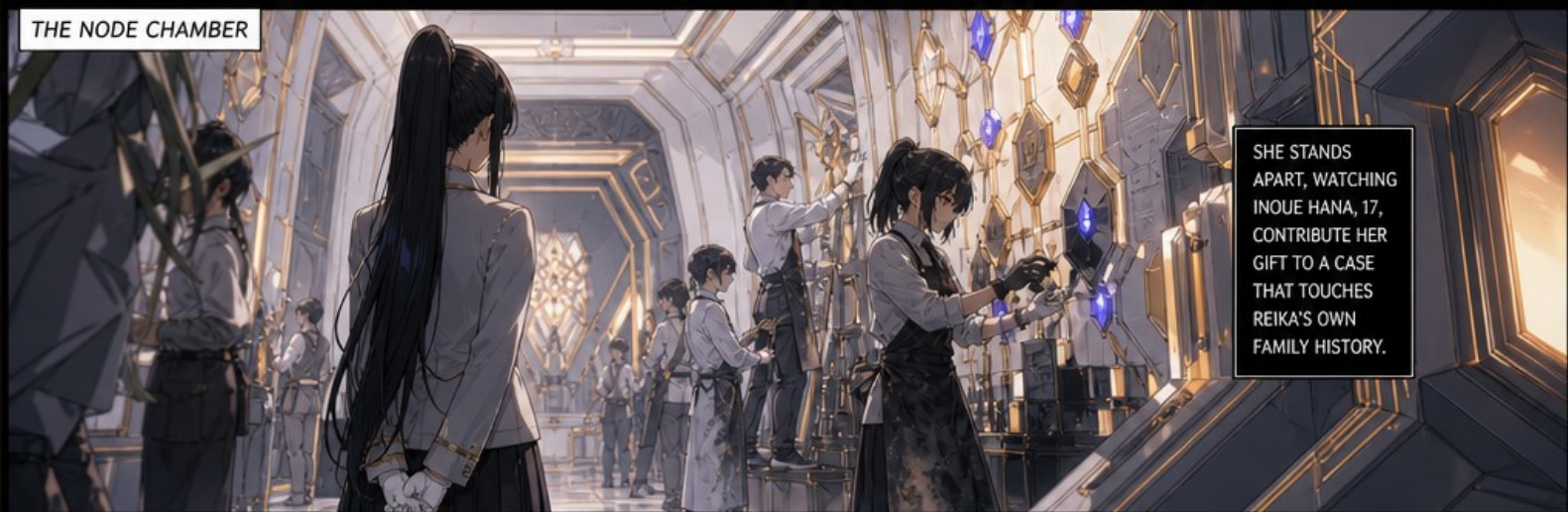
SOMEONE
SEALED IT.

ON PURPOSE.

ISOLATION WAS
THE DESIGN.

PROXIMITY IS
THE TEST.

THE NODE CHAMBER

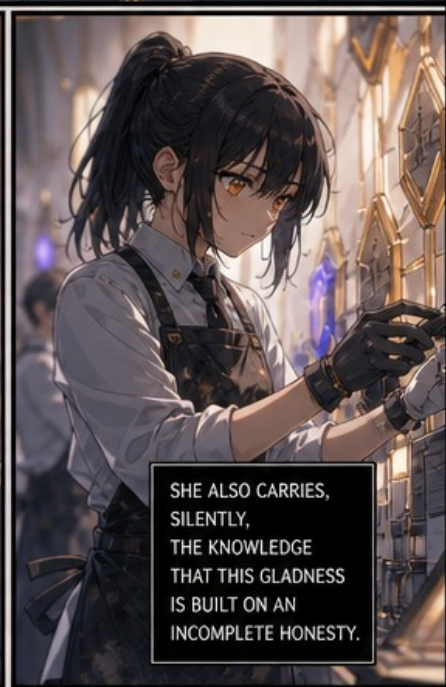
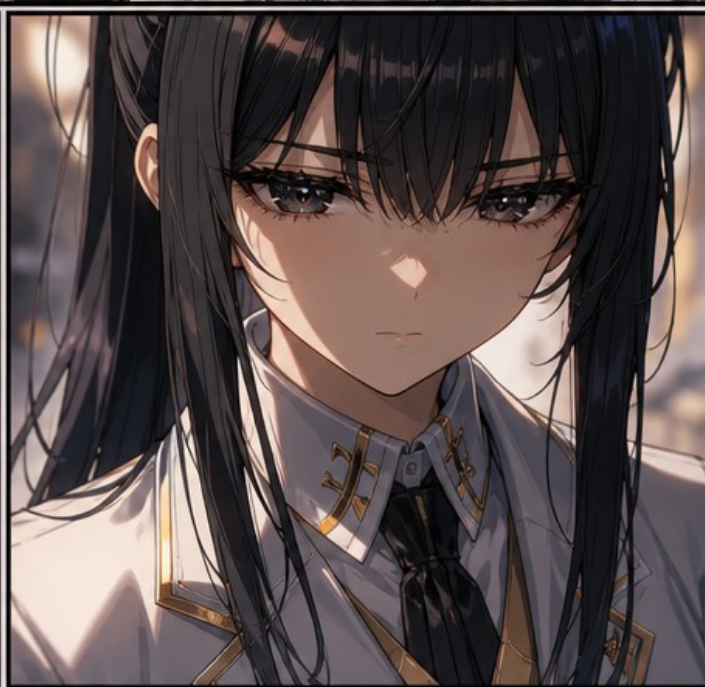


SHE STANDS APART, WATCHING INOUE HANA, 17, CONTRIBUTE HER GIFT TO A CASE THAT TOUCHES REIKA'S OWN FAMILY HISTORY.



SHE IS GLAD INOUE IS HERE.

SHE HAS BROUGHT SOMEONE INTO THE DEEPEST PART OF HER WORLD.



SHE ALSO CARRIES, SILENTLY, THE KNOWLEDGE THAT THIS GLADNESS IS BUILT ON AN INCOMPLETE HONESTY.



A TRUTH THAT CANNOT REMAIN WITHHELD FOREVER.





BASEMENT CLEAR.

THE CASE IS CONNECTED.

EVERYONE FEELS IT NOW.



THIS WING WASN'T BUILT AROUND THE CASE.

THE CASE WAS BUILT AROUND THIS WING.



OLD SYSTEM. OLD LOGIC.

NEW CONNECTION.



IT'S QUIET. DOWN HERE...

...BUT IT'S ALIVE.



EMERGENCY LIGHTING. DRAMATIC AS HELL.



IT KNOWS WE'RE HERE.

IT'S ALWAYS KNOWN.

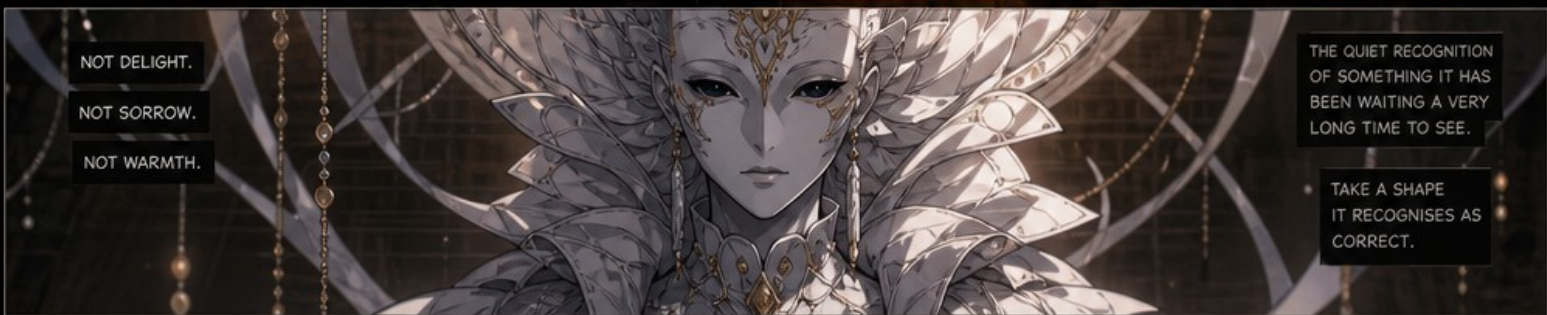


AT THE END OF THE OLD WING, VAEL WAITED.

NOT PERFORMING. NOT SMILING.

JUST WATCHING.

RECOGNIZING.



NOT DELIGHT.

NOT SORROW.

NOT WARMTH.

THE QUIET RECOGNITION OF SOMETHING IT HAS BEEN WAITING A VERY LONG TIME TO SEE.

TAKE A SHAPE IT RECOGNISES AS CORRECT.

OLD WING : AMBER CORRIDOR
FIVE. CONNECTED.

VAEL
ANCIENT FIELD ENTITY

THE CASE IS NO LONGER THEIR BURDEN ALONE.
IT IS THEIR SHAPE NOW.



THE OLD WING
REMEMBERS.

VAEL
IS ALWAYS
WATCHING.

SOME WALLS HAVE EYES.
OTHERS HAVE PURPOSE.

ASTRID BRANDT. 17
THE READER OF THE WEB.

HER GIFT IS ALWAYS
FAINTLY ACTIVE.

SHE SEES THE THREADS
OTHERS CAN'T.

NOT THE FAMILIAR AMBER-BROWN
OF COMPLICITY AND CONCEALMENT.

SOMETHING ELSE.

SOMETHING SHE HAS
NEVER SEEN BEFORE.

THIN. BRIEF.
GONE.

CAREFUL. PRIVATE. SURPRISED.

HER POSTURE STILL.

HER THOUGHTS
MOVE FASTER.

SHE SAYS NOTHING.

SHE NEEDS TIME TO
DISSECT THE IMPOSSIBLE.

THAT NIGHT.

AS SHE ALWAYS DOES.

SHE OPENS HER
GRANDFATHER'S BINDER.

A BLANK PAGE.

SHE WRITES
A SINGLE LINE.

SHE DOES NOT NAME
THE COLOUR.

NOT EVEN TO HERSELF.

SOME THINGS ARE
NOT MEANT TO BE
CAPTURED IN WORDS.

Heute habe ich etwas Neues gesehen.

SHE ALONE WITNESSED IT.

SOMETHING THAT DEFIES
HER ENTIRE COGNITIVE
FRAMEWORK.

THE WEB JUST
GREW A NEW THREAD.

AND SHE IS THE ONLY
ONE WHO SAW IT APPEAR.

EPISODE 17: THE THREAD SHE CANNOT NAME

TO BE CONTINUED.